Rain on the Roof

The big idea

In **Coates Kinney's** poem, the speaker lies in bed in a cottage on a rainy night. The **patter of rain** on the roof brings back sweet **memories of his childhood**, especially of his loving **mother**. The poem is about **nostalgia**, the pleasure of remembering the past.

Summary

- **Stanza 1**: Dark, humid clouds cover the starry sky and the darkness seems to weep in rainy tears. What a joy it is to lie in the bed of a cottage room and listen to the patter of soft rain overhead.
- **Stanza 2**: Every **tinkle on the shingles** has an **echo in the heart**. Many dreamy fancies come alive and a thousand recollections weave their **air-threads into woof**.
- **Stanza 3**: He remembers his **mother**, who used to look fondly at her dreamers before they slept. As he listens to the rain, he imagines her loving look again.

SHINGLES AND WOOF

Shingles: thin rectangular tiles on a roof. **Woof**: threads woven across on a loom. Memories are like threads woven into a fabric of dreams.

Poetic devices

Device	Example
Personification	"melancholy darkness / Gently weeps in rainy tears"

Device	Example
Onomatopoeia	"patter", "tinkle"
Alliteration	"**h**umid... **h**over"; "**s**oft rain over**h**ead"
Metaphor	"air-threads into woof" (memories woven like cloth)
Transferred epithet	"melancholy darkness", "dreamy fancies"
Imagery	sound and visual images of rain and mother

FORM

Three stanzas of eight lines; rhyme scheme is mostly **ABCBDEFE** (alternate lines rhyme), e.g. spheres / tears.

Themes

- **Nostalgia** and the power of memory.
- **Mother's love** as the poet's most precious memory.
- **Nature's link to emotions**: simple sounds can stir deep feelings.

THE MOTHER IS NOT PRESENT

The mother appears only in memory; the poet imagines her loving look. Many write that she comes to his room.

LIKELY QUESTIONS

What does the poet like to do on a rainy day? What memories does the rain bring? Is the poet still a child? (No, he is an adult remembering.) Identify personification in stanza 1.

Quick recap

- Rain on the cottage roof triggers childhood memories.
- Mother's fond look is the strongest memory.
- Devices: personification, onomatopoeia, metaphor.

Practice questions

1. Who is the poet of "Rain on the Roof"?
   (a) Robert Frost (b) Coates Kinney (c) Phoebe Cary (d) Gieve Patel
2. Where is the poet lying when he hears the rain?
   (a) On a beach (b) Under a tree (c) In a cottage chamber bed (d) In a railway carriage
3. "Melancholy darkness gently weeps in rainy tears" contains
   (a) simile (b) personification (c) onomatopoeia (d) hyperbole
4. "Every tinkle on the shingles has an echo in the heart" means
   (a) the roof is noisy (b) the poet is ill (c) each raindrop stirs feelings and memories (d) the poet is afraid of rain
5. Whom does the poet remember most fondly?
   (a) His father (b) His childhood friends (c) His teacher (d) His mother
6. "Patter" and "tinkle" are examples of
   (a) metaphor (b) simile (c) alliteration (d) onomatopoeia
7. What memories does the rain bring back to the poet?

Answers: 1. b 2. c 3. b 4. c 5. d 6. d 7. see notes